MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 4: Silence! The Court Is in Session and The Fire and the Rain

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Tendulkar and Karnad use staged judgement and mythic ritual to expose the distance between proclaimed morality and the exercise of power.

Start with a picture

A game of court turns serious when one participant becomes its target. Elsewhere, a ritual meant to save a community becomes entangled with rivalry and exclusion. Both plays ask who has the authority to judge or sacrifice another person.

1. Silence! The Court Is in Session

Vijay Tendulkar’s play, originally in Marathi and studied in English translation, follows a group preparing a performance. A mock trial becomes an attack on the schoolteacher Leela Benare’s private life.

The participants’ apparent game reveals gossip, professional insecurity, patriarchal assumptions, and pleasure in judgement. Samant’s relative unfamiliarity with the group helps expose what others accept as normal. Sukhatme and the Kashikars participate in the machinery of accusation. Professor Damle’s absence matters because responsibility is distributed unequally.

Benare’s voice

Benare’s energy and assertion do not protect her from the group’s power. Her long expression of experience challenges the terms through which she is being described. Pregnancy and sexuality become occasions for controlling a woman while a man’s responsibility is easier to evade.

The mock sentence has no automatic legal authority, yet the cruelty can have real social force. The play-within-a-play makes the boundary between entertainment and punishment unstable.

2. The Fire and the Rain

Girish Karnad reworks mythic material associated with the Mahabharata. Drought and a prolonged sacrificial ritual create the public situation. Yavakri's pursuit of knowledge, Raibhya's power, and the conflicts involving Paravasu and Arvasu expose rivalry within an apparently sacred order.

Arvasu's relationship with Nittilai challenges caste and community boundaries. Vishakha's experience adds another perspective on desire and male authority. Knowledge, ritual status, and kinship do not guarantee ethical conduct.

Theatre within theatre

Arvasu participates in a performance whose divine conflicts reflect human violence. This resemblance can provoke recognition without reducing every mythic role to one exact human counterpart.

Sacrifice and compassion

The opposition between serving a ritual and responding to another being's suffering becomes central. Rain matters as a dramatic outcome, but an answer must also ask what kind of action the play makes meaningful. Do not praise suffering merely because it has been labelled sacrifice.

3. Compare the plays

One uses an apparently familiar social gathering; the other uses myth, ritual, and performance. Both reveal how authority makes vulnerable people bear the cost of public moral claims. Analyse accusation, silence, a staged role, or a confrontation to show how the audience is positioned.

Quick check

1. Is Benare's trial an ordinary lawful court case? **No; a performance acquires coercive social force.**
2. Does ritual status prove moral superiority in Karnad? **No.**
3. Why use a play within a play? **It lets representation expose the behaviour of those watching or taking part.**

Build an exam answer

1. Identify the institution and performance in each play.
2. Explain the mock trial's transformation.
3. Analyse Benare's voice and unequal judgement.
4. Discuss ritual, rivalry, and Arvasu's performance.
5. Compare the ethical position offered to spectators.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not endorse the group’s treatment of Benare or assume that sacred knowledge and ethical conduct are identical in Karnad.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare the theatrical exposure of moral authority in the two plays.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Both plays place a claim to moral authority inside a performance. In Silence! The Court Is in Session, legal forms make a game appear orderly even as the participants expose private hostility and unequal judgement. The structure does not merely imitate a court; it shows how a community can borrow authoritative language to justify coercion.

Benare’s position makes the gendered distribution of that authority visible. Her speech contests the public account of her life, while the absent male figure is not exposed in an equivalent way. The audience must consequently distinguish the group’s verdict from a judgement the play asks it to accept.

The Fire and the Rain questions a different institution through related means. Myth and sacrifice present large claims about knowledge and communal wellbeing, but personal rivalry and exclusion undermine those claims. The embedded performance allows divine and human conflicts to illuminate each other. Compassion challenges the assumption that correct ritual or superior status is enough for ethical action.

A comparison should connect these themes with dramatic devices: changing tone, the allocation of speech, role-playing, and the reaction of an on-stage audience. The plays’ criticism emerges through the experience of watching authority make itself, not only through individual statements against injustice.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Analyse critically the characterisation of Ms. Leela Benare and Mrs. Kashiker.
2. Examine the play Silence! The Court is in Session as a social satire.
3. Comment on the justification of the title Silence! The Court is in Session.
4. Examine the symbolic significance of ‘fire’ and ‘rain’ in the drama.

5. Comment on the portrayal of gender in the play The Fire and the Rain.
6. Analyse the significance of the ‘play’ within the play The Fire and the Rain.